

THE CHAOS STAR SYNDICALIST MANUAL

Egoism, Absurdity, Ownness, and the Syndicate — A Statement of Chaos Star Syndicalism

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Note on the Name

“catboystirnerite” is a pseudonym. It is not a legal name, an institutional affiliation, or a claim to credentials, and nothing in this document depends on who is behind it.

The choice is not decoration. A pseudonym is the plainest available demonstration of the argument in section VI: a name is taken rather than granted, and a name one has asked permission to use is a name somebody else is holding. The legal name is an administrative handle issued by a state for the state’s convenience in tracking a body, and it is useful for exactly that purpose and no other. It carries no information about the bundle it labels and no authority over it.

The practice has a long history in this particular tradition, and for two distinct reasons which should not be conflated. The first is prudential: labour organizers, anarchists, and individualists have written under assumed names because employers and states have reliably punished them for writing under their own, and there is no reason to hand an adversary a target for nothing.¹ The second is positive, and is the one that matters here: the name one issues to oneself is an instance of ownness, whereas the name one is issued is an instance of registration.

It is worth noting that the founding text of this tradition was itself published under an assumed name, which its author held for the rest of his life in preference to the one on his papers. The precedent is therefore exact.

Readers who find the specific construction of the name unserious are invited to consider that the objection concedes the point. A name that could not be chosen frivolously would be a name held on someone else’s terms. The frivolity is the proof of possession.

A second name is addressed here for the same reason: the position itself, as distinct from the pseudonym of the person stating it, now goes by Chaos Star Syndicalism. The two halves are not decorative. Syndicalism names the organizational content of sections IX through XIII: the union of egoists, and the plain claim that leverage against capital is produced collectively or not at all. Chaos names the rest of the document — the refusal of moral law argued in section III and the refusal of the state’s claim to legitimate authority argued in section XI. Chaos in this sense is not disorder sought for its own sake, which nothing here has recommended; it is the condition that remains once the fixed ideas that were said to hold a moral and a political order in place have been named as fixed ideas, in the manner of proposition 23, and set down. The star is the figure elsewhere given to exactly that condition: a point with no privileged direction and no center asserting one, which is the geometry an amoralist anti-statism is left holding once the compass it was handed has been discarded.

The name is not exempted from the test the document applies to everything else it names. Proposition 87 warns that a union which makes demands in its own name has become a spook; the same test is run here on the name of the tendency the union belongs to. Chaos Star Syndicalism is used because it currently does the work of letting people who hold this position find one another, not because the name has earned a standing independent of that work. Should it stop doing that work, proposition 23 already gives the instruction, and it is followed here as everywhere else: drop it.

Preamble

What follows is a statement of position, not an argument for conversion. It rests on a set of commitments held together as a single structure: a bundle theory of the self; a limited but real account of the will; an error theory of moral discourse; absurdism as the account of meaning; ownness as the relation between a person and their own body and attributes; amorality as practice; the Marxist critique of capital as structural analysis; and anarcho-syndicalism understood as organized self-interest rather than as a moral vocation.

These commitments are usually held apart, and often by people who regard the others as incoherent. Stirner's readers have generally treated class organization as one more abstraction to be dissolved.² Marx, for his part, devoted several hundred pages of *The German Ideology* to ridiculing Stirner under the name "Saint Max."³ Camus and Marxism parted company publicly and permanently.⁴ The position set out here does not paper over those quarrels. It claims that each commitment, taken on its own terms, survives contact with the others — and that several of the supposed conflicts dissolve once moral vocabulary is removed from the argument and replaced with the language of interest, dependency, and leverage.

Two features of the method should be stated in advance. First, no proposition here is defended on the ground that believing it would produce good consequences. That form of argument is unavailable once section III is accepted, and it is in any case the standard route by which useful fictions are readmitted. Second, where the position diverges from a source it draws on, the divergence is marked rather than smoothed over. A synthesis that works only because its components have been quietly softened is not a synthesis.

The propositions are numbered continuously for ease of reference, not because they form a deductive chain; several sections could be read in a different order without loss. Commentary follows each group in smaller type, and carries the citations. This revised edition adds four sections (XV–XVIII) addressing gaps identified after the first edition circulated; they are marked as additions in the text that introduces them and are held to the same standard of marked divergence as everything else.

I. On the Self

Bundle theory; the unique one; the creative nothing

1. There is no persistent substantial self underlying experience. What is named “I” is a bundle of perceptions, impulses, dispositions and memories, unified by continuity and habit rather than by any underlying substance in which they inhere.
2. The bundle’s apparent unity is a product of memory and of the practical convenience of treating it as one thing. Nothing further is required to explain the appearance, and nothing further is discovered when the appearance is investigated.
3. The unity is also partly a construction after the fact. Recollection edits, narrative smooths, and the resulting account of a continuous life is assembled at least as much as it is recorded. This does not make the person fictitious; it makes the person a process rather than an object.
4. A bundle possesses no fixed essence. It therefore cannot be alienated from a nature it never had, cannot be called back to a vocation it was never issued, and owes nothing to any authority claiming to define that nature on its behalf.
5. The absence of a substantial self is not a loss but a subtraction of claims. Every demand that operates by addressing a supposed true self — the soul owed to God, the citizen owed to the nation, the human essence owed to Humanity, the authentic identity owed to a community — loses its addressee.
6. This subtraction applies symmetrically. It removes the claims others make on one’s supposed essence, and it also removes the claims one might wish to make on one’s own behalf by appeal to what one really, deep down, is. There is no such deep down to appeal to, and the appeal was never doing honest work.
7. What remains is not nothing. The bundle wants, acts, and has a stake in outcomes. That is sufficient. No enduring metaphysical subject is required in order to have interests; it is enough to be the site at which the wanting occurs.
8. Nor does the doctrine dissolve the individual into the social. That the bundle is assembled out of materials it did not select — language, upbringing, class position, the categories of section VI — is granted without reservation. It is still this bundle that assembles, and the assembling is not done by society on its behalf.

Hume’s argument is the source. Entering most intimately into what he called himself, he reported finding only particular perceptions and never the self that was supposed to have them, and concluded that a person is a bundle or collection of different perceptions in perpetual flux and movement.⁵ The same conclusion is reached independently and much earlier in the Buddhist doctrine of *anattā*, whose classic illustration is the chariot: the name denotes an assemblage of parts and there is no chariot over and above them, and a person is held to stand in the same relation to the aggregates.⁶ Parfit pressed the reductionism further in the modern literature, arguing through a long series of fission and teletransportation cases that personal identity is not what matters in survival, and that the facts about persons consist in facts about brains, bodies, and interrelated physical and mental events.⁷ Stirner reaches a structurally similar destination by an entirely different road. His *Einzig*, the unique one, is explicitly not an essence to be realized but what he

calls the creative nothing: the nothing out of which the self continually creates itself, and which cannot be fixed into a concept without being falsified.⁸ The difference in route matters for what the doctrine is used for. Hume and Parfit are doing metaphysics and draw no political conclusion; Stirner is doing something closer to a critique of ideology, and the negative result about the self is the instrument by which every claim addressed to the self is disarmed. This document takes the metaphysics from the first and the use from the second.

II. On the Will

Chemistry without fatalism; the level at which choosing happens

9. The bundle is physical. Its states are brain states, its dispositions are chemistry, and its history is a chain of causes it did not select. No exemption from physical law is claimed here, and none is needed.
10. It does not follow that choice is an illusion. Deliberation is itself one of the causes. A process that represents options, projects consequences, and settles on one is doing exactly what choosing consists in; discovering that the process is made of chemistry describes its mechanism rather than abolishing its operation.
11. The inference from “the choice was caused” to “there was no choice” is a category error, and a common one. It treats a description at one level as a refutation of a description at another. Nobody concludes that a calculation did not occur upon learning that the calculator is made of silicon.
12. The demand for a will uncaused by anything prior is a theological demand in secular dress. It asks for a small uncreated creator seated behind the neurons — the same substantial self rejected in section I, smuggled back under a different name.
13. Freedom of the will, so understood, is not a metaphysical exemption but a description of a relation: an action is mine when it issues from my own deliberation and my own wanting, and is not mine when it issues from coercion, compulsion, manipulation, or another’s will working through me.
14. This distinction is the one that actually matters in practice, and it is the only one that ever did. The difference between a worker who stays and a worker who is locked in is not a difference in the determinacy of physics; it is a difference in whose wanting the outcome answers to.
15. Degrees are admitted. A will can be one’s own to a greater or lesser extent, and the conditions under which a person deliberates can be more or less corrupted by hunger, debt, surveillance, addiction, exhaustion, and the manufactured urgency of a wage. This is the point at which the account of the will becomes a political rather than a merely metaphysical matter.
16. It follows that expanding the conditions of genuine deliberation — time, security, information, the material capacity to refuse — is an increase in the will’s ownness and not merely in comfort. The eight-hour day is an epistemological demand as much as an economic one.
17. The error theory of morality is unaffected either way. Responsibility here is not moral desert — there is no such thing — but ownership: the action was mine, issued from me, and I stand behind it because it was mine, not because a ledger records it against my account.
18. Fatalism is therefore rejected as firmly as libertarian free will. “It was always going to happen” is not a reason to stop deliberating, since the deliberating is part of the causal history by which it happens. The person who stops choosing on determinist grounds has not discovered a truth; they have removed themselves from the process by which outcomes get settled.

The position is broadly compatibilist, though it does not require the full apparatus of any particular version. Hume’s treatment already argues that liberty properly means acting according to the

determinations of one's own will, that the opposite of liberty is constraint rather than necessity, and that the dispute has persisted chiefly through ambiguity in the terms.⁹ Frankfurt's refinement locates freedom of the will in the agreement between one's first-order desires and one's second-order desires about which desires should move one to act; the unwilling addict is unfree not because their desire was caused but because it is not the desire they want to be moved by.¹⁰ Strawson's earlier intervention shifted the ground by observing that the practices of holding responsible rest on reactive attitudes which no metaphysical thesis about determinism actually dislodges.¹¹ Dennett's argument is that the varieties of free will worth wanting are entirely compatible with determinism, and that the incompatibilist is chasing a kind of freedom that could not be coherently desired even if it were available.¹² The strongest opposing argument is Galen Strawson's: that to be responsible for one's actions one would have to be responsible for how one is, which would require having chosen the principles on which one chose, and so on without end.¹³ The empirical literature is frequently misreported in popular treatments. Libet's readiness potential experiments are often presented as showing that the brain decides before the person does; the interpretation has been contested on methodological grounds, notably by accumulator models on which the readiness potential reflects ongoing spontaneous fluctuation rather than a decision already taken.¹⁴ The section is included because the bundle theory of section I invites the objection immediately, and because an egoism that cannot say what a choice is has nothing to organize around. Stirner has no theory of the will in this sense; his relevant move is the reduction of right to might, of entitlement to capacity, which points the same way without arguing for it.¹⁵

III. On Morality

Error theory; spooks; the amoralist practice

19. There are no moral facts. Moral claims purport to describe objective, categorically binding features of the world; no such features exist; therefore all positive moral claims are uniformly false.
20. This is a claim about the world, not about language. Moral utterances are genuinely assertoric — they mean what they appear to mean, and are simply mistaken. The error is systematic and deeply embedded, which explains why exposing it changes little in ordinary discourse.
21. The position is therefore distinct from non-cognitivism, which holds that moral utterances are expressions of attitude rather than assertions and so cannot be false. Non-cognitivism is too charitable. People making moral claims do mean to be describing how things stand, and the honest verdict is that they are wrong rather than that they were never trying.
22. What presents itself as moral obligation is, on inspection, the demand of some party wearing the costume of universal authority: God, Humanity, the Nation, the Revolution, Justice, the Greater Good, Rights. These are fixed ideas — spooks — which acquire power over individuals in proportion to those individuals' belief that they stand above them.
23. A fixed idea is identified by a simple test, and the test is practical rather than theoretical: does the thing continue to make demands after it has stopped being useful to the one it makes them of? Anything that answers yes is being served rather than used.
24. Moral discourse performs a function despite being false, and the function is obedience. A person who believes their subjection is merely imposed continues to look for the exit; a person who believes it is righteous will guard the door themselves, unpaid.
25. The historical record supports this without needing to be forced. The moral vocabularies of any given period correspond with unembarrassing closeness to the requirements of its dominant arrangements, and are revised when those requirements change.
26. The rejection of moral law does not abolish reasons for action. Reasons remain, grounded in what the acting individual actually wants and in the situation they actually occupy, rather than in a law claiming jurisdiction from outside.
27. Preferences are not arbitrary merely because they are not objective. They are the products of a particular history, body, and situation, and they are as stable and as motivating as anything in a person's life. The demand that a preference be cosmically underwritten before it may be acted on is a demand nobody has ever actually met.
28. This position is amoralist, not misanthropic. It does not license cruelty; it observes that cruelty rarely serves the one who practises it, that most people want very little of it, and that these observations were always doing the work the moral prohibition took credit for.
29. Amoralism is likewise not nihilism in the sense of holding that nothing matters. It holds that what matters, matters to someone, and requires no further licence than that.
30. The practical consequence is not lawlessness but the removal of a layer of pretence. Disputes that were conducted as disagreements about what is Right become disputes about what the parties want and what each can do, which is what they were in any case.

The technical statement is Mackie's. His opening claim is that there are no objective values; ordinary moral judgement carries a built-in claim to objectivity, and since that claim is false the judgements incorporating it are false too — hence “error theory.” He supports it chiefly with two arguments. The argument from relativity takes the actual variation in moral codes across societies as better explained by their differing ways of life than by differential perception of a common objective truth. The argument from queerness observes that objective values would have to be entities or qualities of a very strange sort, utterly different from anything else in the universe, and would require a correspondingly strange faculty of moral perception to detect them.¹⁶ Mackie himself did not draw amoralist conclusions; the later chapters of the same book set out to invent morality, treating it as a useful human institution to be constructed knowingly rather than discovered.¹⁷ Stirner arrives at the same destination without the analytic apparatus and a century and a half earlier. The sacred, whatever its content, is for him whatever has been elevated above the individual and then obeyed; the task is not to replace one sacred thing with a better one but to consume it.¹⁸ His target is expressly the humanist inheritors of Christianity: Feuerbach had relocated the divine predicates into Man, and Stirner's objection is that this leaves the structure of religion entirely intact while changing the name of the thing one kneels to.¹⁹ Both moves are required here. Mackie establishes that the claim is false; Stirner explains why it persists anyway, and why the exposure of one sacred object is so regularly followed by the elevation of another.

IV. On the Absurd

Absurdism; the refusal of consolation; revolt without hope

31. The universe furnishes no meaning. It is not hostile, which would at least be a kind of attention; it is silent. Meaning is not discovered in it and cannot be, because there is nothing there of that kind to discover.
32. The absurd is not a property of the world, nor of the person, but of the relation between them. It arises from the confrontation between a mind that demands sense and a world that returns none. Remove either term and the absurd disappears.
33. It follows that the absurd cannot be resolved by acquiring information. No discovery about the structure of the cosmos would supply the missing term, because the missing term is not a fact of that kind.
34. Two evasions are available and both are refused here. The first is physical suicide, which resolves the confrontation by deleting one party to it. The second is philosophical suicide: the leap into some transcendent guarantor — God, History, the Party, Progress, the Meaning of It All — which resolves the confrontation by inventing an answer.
35. The second evasion is the more dangerous, because it is available in secular form and is therefore invisible to people who believe they have already discarded religion. A movement which promises that the arc of history bends toward its programme has relocated Providence, not abolished it, and will demand the same sacrifices on the same terms.
36. The test for philosophical suicide is the same test given for a fixed idea in proposition 26. A guarantor which requires that present costs be paid against a future it alone certifies is being served, not used.
37. What remains is revolt: living without appeal. Not despair, which is still an attitude toward a meaning that failed to arrive, and not resignation, which is despair that has stopped complaining. Revolt is the continued exercise of one's own interests in full view of the fact that nothing underwrites them.
38. Absurdism and error theory are the same conclusion reached in two registers. Error theory denies objective value; absurdism denies objective meaning. Neither denial prevents anything from mattering to the person to whom it matters, and both remove the same class of external claim.
39. Absurdism supplies what egoism alone does not: a settled relation to the fact that one's own projects are ungrounded. The egoist who has not made peace with this tends to smuggle a private absolute back in and call it authenticity, or will, or nature, or the market.
40. Nothing in this counsels detachment. The absence of a guarantor is a reason to hold one's own commitments more firmly rather than less, since there is now nothing else holding them.

Camus opens by naming suicide the one truly serious philosophical problem, on the ground that it is the question of whether life is worth living once the appeal to inherent meaning has failed, and that everything else comes afterward.²⁰ His account of the absurd is relational rather than metaphysical: it is born of the confrontation between the human demand for clarity and the unreasonable silence of the world, and it is this divorce, not either term taken alone, that constitutes it.²¹ The charge of

philosophical suicide is directed at thinkers who acknowledge the absurd clearly and then escape it by a leap into transcendence, and Camus's demand is that the absurd be kept alive rather than resolved — that one live without appeal.²² The extension into politics is *The Rebel*, whose argument against revolutionary terror is precisely that movements claiming historical necessity license present killing against a future they alone underwrite, and that rebellion which accepts this has abandoned the ground it began from.²³ That argument is retained here in full, and it is the reason the position below is syndicalist and anti-statist rather than vanguardist: the objection to the vanguard is not that it is impractical but that it is a guarantor. Nagel's later treatment differs in tone and in diagnosis, locating absurdity in the collision between the seriousness with which we necessarily take our lives and the permanent availability of a standpoint from which that seriousness looks arbitrary, and recommending irony rather than heroism as the response.²⁴ Both are compatible with what follows, and the choice between them is a matter of temperament rather than doctrine.

V. On Death

Mortality without transcendence; the bundle's end as a fact rather than a meaning

41. The bundle ends. Nothing survives it: not a soul, which section I has already denied, and not a self which could be the subject of a subsequent condition.
42. Death is therefore not an event in a life and not a state that is undergone. There is no moment at which one is dead in the way there are moments at which one is cold or in pain, because the subject required for undergoing has been subtracted.
43. This removes a specific fear, though not all of them. The fear of being dead — of some enduring deprived condition — has no object. The fear of dying, which is a fear of a process that does have a subject, is entirely rational and is not touched by the argument.
44. Nor does the argument remove the ordinary preference for more life over less. That a state of deprivation is never occupied does not establish that the loss is not a loss; it establishes only that there will be nobody present to register it.
45. Death supplies no meaning, and least of all a retrospective one. A life is not completed, summed, or interpreted by ending, any more than a sentence is interpreted by running out of paper.
46. The specific temptation here is to treat death as the guarantor that section IV refused: to hold that mortality confers urgency, and that urgency confers significance. It does not. Scarcity explains why a thing is prized; it does not establish that the thing was underwritten.
47. What mortality does supply is a constraint, and constraints are where interests become concrete. A finite bundle must choose between incompatible uses of its time, which is the condition under which having interests amounts to anything at all.
48. This bears directly on the question of work. An employer purchases hours, and hours are the only genuinely non-renewable thing the worker possesses. The wage relation is therefore not merely an exchange of value for value, but an exchange of an irreplaceable commodity for a replaceable one, conducted under duress.
49. Sacrifice of one's life for a cause is refused on the same grounds as every other sacrifice, and more firmly. There is no ledger in which the payment is recorded and no subsequent condition in which the return is collected.
50. This is not a prohibition on risk. Risk undertaken for stakes one actually holds is ordinary and sometimes correct. What is refused is the specific transaction in which a life is spent for a guarantor's promissory note.

Epicurus supplies the classical argument in a single move: death is nothing to us, since when we exist death is not present, and when death is present we do not exist, so it concerns neither the living nor the dead.²⁵ The argument is sound against the fear of being dead and is adopted here for that purpose only. Nagel's reply identifies its limit: the Epicurean move shows that death is not experienced, but a deprivation account of the badness of death does not require that it be experienced, only that it removes goods the person would otherwise have had.²⁶ Camus's treatment is a third thing again, and is the one that matters for section IV: he treats mortality not as an evil to be argued away but as one of the two terms whose collision produces the absurd, so that arguing

it away would dissolve the very confrontation he insists on keeping open.²⁷ Proposition 45 is the load-bearing one for what follows. It connects this section to section VIII: the critique of the wage relation acquires its force from finitude, since an hour sold is not an hour deferred. Marx makes the same connection in the chapter on the working day, where the extension of hours appears as the direct appropriation of the worker's lifetime and the shortening of their life is treated as a cost borne entirely by them.²⁸

VI. On the Body and Its Spooks

Ownness against freedom; gender, race, and the attributes one holds as property

51. The body is not a vessel containing a self. It is part of the bundle, and it is the part through which every other part acts. It is not owed to a god who made it, a state that counts it, a family that produced it, a doctor who classifies it, or a public that has opinions about it.
52. The relevant relation is ownness (*Eigenheit*), not freedom. Freedom is negative and granted: it is the removal of a constraint by someone in a position to remove it, and what is granted can be withdrawn. Ownness is the standing fact of the thing being mine, which requires no permission and survives its refusal.
53. To wait for permission to be what one is — from the law, from medicine, from a community, from a movement, from an ideology — is to have conceded ownership in advance and to be negotiating for its return on the other party's terms.
54. This is not a claim that permission is never worth seeking. It is a claim about what seeking it means. One may apply to an institution for a document, a procedure, or a resource as a matter of tactics, while conceding nothing about who the thing belonged to beforehand.
55. Gender, race, nationality, caste, diagnosis, and every comparable category are spooks in the precise technical sense established in proposition 26: fixed ideas, socially maintained, which present themselves as facts about a person's nature and then issue instructions on the strength of it.
56. Calling them spooks is not calling them unreal. They are enormously real in their effects: they allocate wages, housing, medical care, police attention, violence, and death with great consistency and considerable statistical regularity. What is denied is not their operation but their authority — the claim that they describe an essence which obliges the person described.
57. The distinction between a real effect and a real essence is the whole of the argument here. A border is not a fact of geology and it still stops a body. A category can be socially constructed from top to bottom and remain the most consequential thing about a person's week.
58. Consistency with section I requires this treatment. If there is no substantial self, there is no true gender or real race underneath the social one, waiting to be uncovered by sufficiently careful introspection. The essentialist and the reformer who merely reassigns the essence are making the same mistake from opposite ends.
59. What follows is not that these attributes must be discarded, which is neither possible nor desirable, but that they are held as property rather than as identity. They may be worn, used, refused, altered, inhabited, played with, or set down, in whole or in part, and the decision answers to the one holding them and to nobody else.
60. Ownership of an attribute includes ownership of its presentation: name, pronoun, dress, body, modification, voice, and the entire apparatus of how one appears. These are taken, not requested. A name one has asked permission for is a name someone else is holding.
61. The category one was assigned is not thereby made illegitimate to keep. A person who retains the gender, name, or affiliation they were handed, having examined it and found it serviceable, holds it on exactly the same terms as one who discards it: as property, not as fate.

62. Nor is any obligation generated toward others who share a category. A shared assignment is not a shared essence and does not constitute a union in the sense of section IX. Where obligation appears it is because a dependency is present, and the dependency will bear examination on its own.
63. Ownness does not abolish the material consequences these categories carry. Where a category is used as an instrument of subjection, it is opposed on the same grounds as any other imposed authority: as an attack on one's own position, not as an offence against justice, which does not exist.
64. This has a direct organizational consequence, developed in section IX. A workforce sorted by race, gender, citizenship, or documentation is a workforce with a seam in it, and the seam is where capital applies pressure. Opposing that sorting is not charity extended to others; it is the removal of a handle by which one's own position is broken.

Stirner's distinction between freedom and ownness is the pivot of his second part. Freedom, he argues, is merely being rid of something, remains in the keeping of whoever granted it, and can therefore always be revoked; ownness is the individual's whole existence as their own, from which nothing is subtracted by permission because none was given.²⁹ His treatment of the body and its powers as property belongs to the same discussion, where what one has is a matter of what one can hold rather than what one is licensed to hold.³⁰ The application to race and gender is not Stirner's and is made here. It converges with two independent lines of argument. Appiah's critique holds that races in the biological sense do not exist — the term has no referent answering to the essentialist picture — while racial identities do a great deal of real social work, so that the category must be assessed by its effects rather than by a referent it lacks.³¹ Butler's account of gender as performative — constituted by repeated stylized acts rather than expressing a prior inner essence — converges with the bundle theory almost exactly, and Beauvoir's earlier formulation that one is not born but rather becomes a woman is the same thought in a different idiom.³² One divergence must be marked rather than elided, since it is the obvious line of attack. Butler explicitly denies that performativity is voluntarist, rejecting the picture of a subject who selects a gender each morning as one selects clothes from a wardrobe, on the ground that the subject is itself constituted in and by the norms it would be choosing among.³³ The position here accepts the constitution point in full and declines the conclusion drawn from it. That a bundle is assembled out of materials it did not choose is exactly what propositions 8 and 9 already concede, and it no more prevents the bundle from taking hold of those materials than any other causal history prevents any other choice. The disagreement is not about metaphysics, on which the two accounts agree; it is the disagreement of section II, reappearing in a different vocabulary.

VII. On Property and Possession

What is held against what is titled

65. Property in the legal sense is a relation between persons enforced by violence, described as a relation between a person and a thing. The description is the ideological part; the enforcement is the real one.
66. A title deed is not a fact about land. It is a standing instruction to armed men, and its efficacy depends entirely on their continued willingness to follow it.
67. Possession is distinct from property and is prior to it. What one possesses is what one holds, uses, and can defend; what one owns is what an authority certifies one may call on it to defend. The first requires no permission and the second is nothing but permission.
68. The egoist position on property is therefore not that property is theft, which presupposes a legitimate distribution from which the theft is a departure, nor that property is sacred, which is the same error with the sign reversed. It is that property is a fact about power dressed as a fact about entitlement.
69. This dissolves the apparent disagreement between the individualist who defends property and the communist who abolishes it, insofar as both are arguing about entitlement. The operative question is never who ought to have the thing, but who has it and on what basis it is held.
70. Applied to the means of production, the analysis yields the ordinary syndicalist conclusion by a non-standard route. The factory is not rightfully the workers'; rightful is a spook. It is held by its owner through a legal instrument backed by state force, and it is within the workers' capacity to hold it otherwise.
71. Occupancy and use is preferred to title as a standard, not because it is more just, but because it is the arrangement under which possession and entitlement coincide and the enforcement apparatus becomes redundant.
72. Personal possessions are not threatened by any of this and the frequent suggestion that they are is a debating tactic rather than an argument. A toothbrush is held and used by the person holding and using it. A factory held by someone who has never entered it is a different kind of object entirely, and the difference is not one of scale but of whether the holding requires an external apparatus to sustain it.

Proudhon's formula that property is theft is refused here in its own terms while its target is retained: the slogan presupposes a rightful distribution against which the theft is measured, which is precisely the kind of claim section III has removed.³⁴ Stirner's treatment is the direct source for propositions 60 and 61: he holds that what he has in his power is his own, that he is entitled to as much as he is able to take, and that the appeal to rights in property disputes is an appeal to the very authority whose decision is in question.³⁵ The American individualist anarchists developed the occupancy-and-use standard of proposition 64 at length, generally accepting Stirnerite egoism while retaining a market in products.³⁶ The point at which this document parts from that tradition is the market: nothing in the egoist analysis of property recommends competitive exchange as the successor arrangement, and sections IX and X give the reasons for preferring the syndicate. Kropotkin's objection to the individualists is accepted on the empirical part — that production is

already social and cannot be disaggregated into individual contributions for the purpose of payment — while his ethical framework is not.³⁷

VIII. On Capital

The critique as structural description, not moral indictment

73. Capital is accumulated past labour set in command over present labour. Its authority is positional, not moral: it consists in ownership of the means through which the worker must act in order to live.
74. The wage contract is formally equal and materially asymmetric. The worker sells labour-power, the only commodity they reliably possess, and sells it because the alternative is destitution. The exchange can be perfectly fair by every standard internal to commodity exchange and still transfer value in one direction.
75. This is the analytically important point and the one most often lost. The critique does not allege cheating. It shows that no cheating is necessary, and that the result follows from the ordinary operation of exchange between parties who are formally equal and materially unequal.
76. Surplus value is the gap between the value the worker produces and the value returned as wages. It is not a deduction from a prior just wage; it is the reason the transaction is entered into by the purchasing party at all.
77. The worker's own past hours return as the instrument of their subordination. The plant was built by labour, is owned as capital, and confronts the next generation of workers as a condition they must accept in order to work at all.
78. The critique of capital requires no appeal to justice, to rights, to History, or to humanity's destiny. It requires only the observable relation between production and return, and the observable use made of that relation.
79. It follows that the critique survives the error theory intact. It was never a moral argument. Nothing in it is weakened by the claim that exploitation is not "wrong" in any objective sense; what it describes remains exactly the case, and the person it describes remains in exactly the same position.
80. Opposition to capital is therefore a matter of interest rather than conscience. Capital is opposed because it is a standing and concrete threat to the position of the one opposing it, and to everyone whose labour-power it draws on.
81. Competition among capitals compels individual capitalists to behave in ways no individual among them need have chosen. This is why the analysis is structural and why personal denunciation of employers is largely beside the point: replacing the holder of a position does not alter what the position requires.
82. Marx's analysis is accepted here as analysis and rejected as eschatology. The account of the commodity, of labour-power, of surplus value, and of the working day is retained. The philosophy of history, the necessary succession of stages, the guaranteed outcome, and the dictatorship of the proletariat are not.
83. The reason for the rejection is given in section IV and is not opportunistic. A guaranteed outcome is a guarantor, a guarantor licenses present costs against a future it certifies, and the historical record of that structure is available for inspection.

The Stirnerite objection to Marx is not the economics. It is “Saint Max” in reverse: the suspicion that History, the Proletariat, and the eventual society have been installed as new absolutes in the position vacated by God, and that the vocabulary of necessity performs the same function as the vocabulary of providence. That suspicion is shared here and is what the next sections are built to avoid.

IX. On the Union of Egoists

Solidarity reconstructed as dependency; the syndicate as instrument

84. Organization with other workers is not owed to class loyalty, shared essence, or the sacredness of solidarity. It is adopted because it works: leverage against concentrated capital is produced collectively or it is not produced at all.
85. The isolated refusal is negligible and the coordinated refusal is a threat. This is not an inspiring observation, merely a true one, and it is sufficient by itself to generate the entire syndicalist programme from self-interest without any moral premise whatever.
86. The appropriate form is the union of egoists: an association entered into for the sake of its members' own interests, sustained only while it serves them, and left without residual obligation when it does not. It is a relation one owns, not one that owns its participants.
87. This is distinguished from the fixed institution which, having been founded as an instrument, comes to be treated as an end and to make demands in its own name. A union that requires sacrifice for the sake of the union has become a spook, and is identified as one by the test in proposition 26.
88. The distinction is not academic. It is the practical difference between a fighting organization and a business union which manages its members' discontent as a service sold to the employer, and the second is what the first reliably becomes when it is permitted to become an end.
89. Because the individual's leverage is constituted by the association holding together, an injury to a fellow member is properly treated as an injury to oneself. This is not moral extension and not sentiment. The union's strength is the individual's strength; damage to it is damage to one's own position.
90. The old syndicalist formula — an injury to one is an injury to all — is therefore retained, but its foundation is replaced. It is not an ethical claim about shared humanity. It is a description of how leverage is actually constituted and actually lost.
91. The replacement is not a weakening. A person who holds the formula on egoist grounds will act on it in precisely the cases where it matters, whereas a person who holds it as a moral principle will act on it in the cases where acting is comfortable and discover sophisticated reasons in the others.
92. The scope of this identification is fixed by the actual structure of dependency and extends exactly as far as that structure runs. Where an employer can break one shop by supplying another, whipsaw locals against each other, relocate production, or draw replacement labour from an unorganized pool, the dependency is real and wide, and so is the injury.
93. Where no such link exists, no obligation is manufactured to imitate one. The boundary is drawn by causation, not by conscience, and there is no court above the individual before which the boundary must be justified.
94. In practice the dependency runs considerably further than it appears to at any given moment, because capital is mobile and labour markets are connected. Most cases in which solidarity appears to demand sacrifice are in fact cases in which the dependency is real but the time horizon is long and the causal chain is not visible from the shop floor.

95. The long horizon is not a concession to moral solidarity by another name. It is an ordinary feature of self-interested reasoning, and any egoism unable to accommodate delayed returns would also be unable to justify learning a trade.
96. Sympathy action, secondary support, and the organization of the unorganized are accordingly defended here on egoist grounds: not as generosity, but as maintenance of the conditions under which one's own refusal retains force.
97. The same reasoning covers every division by which a workforce is sorted and set against itself, whether by race, sex, citizenship, documentation, contract status, or trade. A seam is a place where pressure is applied. Closing it is self-defence conducted at the level where the attack actually occurs.
98. Reciprocity is the mechanism by which such an association is stabilized, and it requires no altruism to function. In a relationship expected to continue, the cost of defection is the loss of future cooperation, and that cost is borne by the defector.
99. It follows that the union's internal discipline is not a moral matter either. The sanctions applied to a member who crosses a line are not punishments in a desert sense; they are the price signals by which a cooperative arrangement remains one.

Stirner's association of egoists is set against both the state and the fixed society. The union is meant to be one's own instrument, entered for one's own sake and used up in the using; where it hardens into a society standing over its members, it has become another master and is to be treated as one.³⁸ Landstreicher's translation renders the key terms differently throughout and restores some of the emphasis on dissolubility that the older English is accused of flattening.³⁹ The syndicalist tradition supplies the content Stirner leaves abstract. Rucker's exposition presents anarcho-syndicalism as direct economic organization by the producers themselves, hostile to political parties and to the conquest of state power, with the union serving both as a weapon in the present struggle and as the framework of a later arrangement.⁴⁰ The formula of proposition 82 is the standard labour slogan, given programmatic form in the IWW preamble's insistence that the working class and the employing class have nothing in common.⁴¹ The organizational model — unions as both instruments of struggle and the skeleton of a successor arrangement — comes from the French tradition and is stated in the Charter of Amiens, which asserts the union's independence from all political parties and sects while pursuing immediate improvements and eventual expropriation together.⁴² The theoretical support for propositions 89 and 90 is not anarchist in origin and is stronger for it. Axelrod's tournament work established that conditional reciprocity outperforms both unconditional cooperation and unconditional defection in iterated interaction, and that it does so without any assumption of benevolence among the players.⁴³ Ostrom's field research established that groups facing common-pool resource problems regularly devise durable self-governing arrangements without either privatization or state enforcement, and identified the design features such arrangements share.⁴⁴ The move made in this section is to keep the syndicalist tactic and discard its ethical footing, replacing shared humanity with shared exposure. The result is narrower in principle and, in the overwhelming majority of real disputes, identical in practice. The name under which this position circulates, Chaos Star Syndicalism, is held on the same terms as the union it names: adopted because it is useful for finding one another, not because it has been elevated above the finding.

X. On the Free Rider

The hardest objection, stated at full strength and answered

This section is set apart because the objection it addresses is the only one that threatens the structure rather than a detail of it, and because the usual replies are bad.

100. The objection: if each member acts only on self-interest, then the rational member takes the benefits the union wins and contributes nothing, since the contract covers them either way and their individual contribution is negligible to the outcome. Egoism therefore does not generate the union; it generates scabs.
101. The objection is not a debating point. It is the standard result in the analysis of collective action, holds generally for large groups pursuing non-excludable benefits, and cannot be dismissed by asserting that people are better than that.
102. The first part of the reply is that the benefits of union membership are substantially excludable in practice, and that the historical forms of union organization are largely devices for making them so. Hiring halls, apprenticeship control, closed shops, benefit funds, and the informal sanctions of a shop floor are all mechanisms by which the non-contributor is separated from the return.
103. This is not a regrettable coercive residue within a voluntary arrangement. It is the arrangement functioning, and it is what proposition 90 anticipates: the sanction is the mechanism by which a cooperative arrangement remains cooperative under egoist conditions.
104. The second part of the reply is that the interaction is iterated and the participants are identifiable. The free-rider result is strongest for anonymous single-shot interaction among large numbers; a workplace is a small group of people who will see each other daily for years, which is the condition under which conditional reciprocity dominates.
105. The third part is that the benefit at stake is not primarily the contract won in this round. It is the standing capacity to win future rounds, and that capacity is degraded directly by defection. The free rider is not taking a benefit without paying; they are converting a durable asset into a one-off payment, most of the cost of which lands on them.
106. The fourth part is that the calculation the objection models is available to the employer as well, and the employer has been running it for longer. A workforce known to be composed of free riders will be treated accordingly, and the resulting terms are the real comparison case rather than the terms won by a union one has declined to support.
107. Where these four fail, the objection succeeds, and the honest answer is that the union will fail there too. Egoist syndicalism does not claim that solidarity is always rational; it claims that it is rational under identifiable conditions and specifies them, which is more than the moral account does.
108. The moral account's apparent advantage at this point is illusory. It does not solve the free-rider problem; it relabels the free rider as a bad person while leaving their incentives untouched, and organizations relying on that relabelling have not historically outperformed organizations relying on hiring halls.

The replies in propositions 95 and 96 rest on Axelrod's iteration results and on Ostrom's documentation of durable self-governing arrangements which manage exactly this problem through graduated sanctions and mutual monitoring rather than through privatization or external enforcement; her design principles are, read from the other direction, a list of the conditions under which the Olson result does not hold. The empirical literature on union security arrangements bears on proposition 94 and should be consulted by anyone organizing rather than merely reading.

XI. On Force, Law, and the State

Legitimacy as the spook; the monopoly as the fact

109. The state is the human community which successfully claims a monopoly on the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory. The definition is accurate and is adopted here without the approval its author attached to it.
110. The word doing the work in that definition is “legitimate,” and it is a spook. Remove it and what remains is the successful claim of a monopoly on physical force, which is an accurate description of a protection racket that has achieved market dominance.
111. Law is not a separate thing from force. It is the schedule according to which force is applied, published in advance for the convenience of those applying it and the predictability of those subject to it.
112. Predictability is a real benefit and should be acknowledged as one. A schedule of violence one can read is better than a schedule one cannot, and this accounts for most of what people actually value in the rule of law.
113. It does not follow that the schedule binds. To know that an act carries a penalty is to know a fact about the world, of the same kind as knowing that a roof is unstable. Nothing further is added by the claim that one ought to obey.
114. The state’s central function with respect to capital is enforcement of title, as section VII established. The property relation is a standing instruction to armed men, and the state is the institution which keeps them available.
115. Its second function is the management of the labour relation: setting the terms on which unions may act, which actions are permitted, which are penalized, and which are unthinkable. Legal recognition of a union is not a victory neutrally granted. It is the conversion of an uncontrolled capacity into a licensed and therefore revocable one.
116. Nothing is owed to the state beyond what it extracts by force, and compliance with it carries the same status as compliance with any other superior force: a tactical matter, assessed case by case, generating no residue of obligation.
117. Nothing is owed to any party or organization which requests the submission of one’s will in place of one’s ongoing consent. The vanguard is refused for the reason given in section IV: it is philosophical suicide with a membership card.
118. The seizure of state power is refused on the same grounds and not on grounds of squeamishness. An apparatus built to concentrate force will concentrate it regardless of the intentions of those who capture it, and the capturing party becomes the thing it captured with a regularity that is no longer possible to treat as accidental.

Weber’s definition is used in proposition 100 in the form he gave it, as a value-free sociological description rather than an endorsement; he was explicit that the state cannot be defined by its ends, only by its specific means.⁴⁵ Bakunin’s argument against the conquest of state power — that the workers’ state produces a new governing class of ex-workers who cease to be workers upon governing — is the source of proposition 109 and predates the events that confirmed it by half a century.⁴⁶ The analysis of legal recognition in proposition 106 is standard within the syndicalist tradition and

is one of its more durable predictions; Rocker's objection to parliamentary methods rests on it, and the subsequent history of state-recognized labour relations in most industrial countries has not falsified it.⁴⁷

XII. On Intercourse

Association beyond the workplace; love, friendship, and obligation

119. The analysis of section IX is not restricted to workplaces. Every association is either a union in the sense given there or a fixed institution making demands in its own name, and the distinction applies to families, friendships, marriages, and households without modification.
120. Love is not diminished by being described in egoist terms and is in fact described more accurately. A person is loved because the loving is one's own, arises from one's own wanting, and is enjoyed as such — not because the beloved holds a claim which the lover discharges.
121. The specific thing refused is the transformation of an affection into a duty. The moment a relationship persists because it is owed rather than because it is wanted, it has become a fixed institution by the test in proposition 26, and what remains is the administration of a corpse.
122. Obligations freely undertaken are not thereby binding in perpetuity. A promise is a prediction about one's future conduct which one has a present interest in making accurate, and that interest is usually strong; but a promise that binds independently of every interest in keeping it is a claim of the kind section III has removed.
123. This is not a licence for casual betrayal, and the suggestion that it is mistakes the argument for its caricature. Reliability is among the most valuable things a person can possess, it is built only by being reliable, and it is destroyed by exactly the conduct the objection imagines egoism recommending.
124. The family is a union that is unusually well disguised as a natural fact. Descent is a biological relation and generates no claims whatever; what generates claims is a set of arrangements which can be examined, kept, renegotiated, or left on the same terms as any other.
125. Care for dependents — children, the ill, the old — is not excluded by any of this and does not require a moral premise. It is wanted, it is the price of having the relationships one wants to have, and the person who requires an argument from duty before feeding a child has a problem that no argument will reach. (Section XVI, added below, returns to this proposition and marks its limit.)
126. The consistent position is therefore neither the dissolution of attachment nor its sanctification, but its possession: relationships held as one's own, maintained because they are wanted, and examined periodically to confirm that this is still why they are being maintained.

Proposition 115 is a standing vulnerability of egoist positions and is best addressed directly rather than by assurance. The reply given is the one that follows from section IX: reliability is a capital asset, accumulated only by expenditure, and iterated interaction among identifiable parties is exactly the condition under which the consistently honest party outperforms the opportunist. This is Axelrod's result applied to private life, and it is why the egoist account of promising is less permissive in practice than it sounds in statement. The reply is complete only for relationships in which both parties can affect each other's position over time; where that condition fails, the difficulty is not addressed here but in section XVI.

XIII. On Practice and Method

What is done, on what terms, and with what instruments

127. No sacrifice is owed to a Cause, because there is no Cause. There is an association, useful at present, carried while useful, and set down without ceremony and without apology when it is not.
128. Risk undertaken on behalf of the union is a calculated wager on future leverage, not an act of self-abnegation. It is taken because coordinated refusal has consistently outperformed isolated refusal wherever it has been tried, not because refusal is virtuous in itself.
129. Direct action is preferred to representation for reasons of interest rather than purity. Delegated power is power one no longer holds, and the historical record of its voluntary return to the delegating party is thin.
130. The strike is the central instrument because it is the point at which the dependency runs the other way. Capital requires labour continuously and labour requires wages periodically, and the whole of syndicalist tactics consists in exploiting the difference between those two intervals.
131. It follows that the strike fund, the benefit society, and every other arrangement that lengthens the interval a worker can survive without wages is not a peripheral welfare function but a direct augmentation of striking power.
132. Mutual aid is defended on the same basis and requires no appeal to fellow feeling. An association whose members can survive a lockout is an association that can call one, and the provision is therefore a weapon rather than a charity.
133. Rank-and-file control and recallable delegates are preferred to standing officialdom, for the reason given in proposition 78: an instrument permitted to become an end will become one, and the officials are where that transformation begins.
134. The general strike is treated as a tactic with a known record rather than as a culminating event. Where it is held as the latter it functions as a guarantor in the sense of section IV, and is subject to the same objection as every other guarantor.
135. Sabotage, work-to-rule, the slowdown, and the occupation are instruments assessed by their consequences for the position of those employing them. No moral distinction is drawn between them and the strike, because there is no moral distinction to draw; the distinctions that matter are tactical and are considerable.
136. Violence is assessed on the same footing and with the additional observation that it is usually a losing wager against a party holding the monopoly described in section XI. The objection to armed confrontation with a state is not that it is wrong but that it is almost always the fight one's opponent would choose.
137. Organizing the unorganized is the highest-return activity available, for the reason given in propositions 83 and 86. Every unorganized worker is a reserve the employer holds against those organized, and the reserve is dissolved by organizing rather than by condemning those who fill it.
138. Consistency is not owed to this document. It is a record of a position held for reasons, and it

should be abandoned in any part where the reasons stop holding. A manifesto that demands loyalty to itself has made the same mistake as everything it criticizes.

The tactical repertoire described here is the classical syndicalist one, documented across the tradition's own literature rather than derived from first principles. Kropotkin's argument for mutual aid is used in proposition 124 for its empirical content — that cooperation within species is a widespread and successful strategy rather than an exception requiring special explanation — and not for the ethical conclusions he drew from it.⁴⁸ Proposition 126 requires a word, since it rejects the tradition's most famous formulation of its own central tactic. Sorel treated the general strike explicitly as a myth — an image whose function is to organize sentiment and produce action, and whose truth or practicability is beside the point.⁴⁹ That is a spook advocated knowingly, and the objection to it is the objection of proposition 26 rather than a complaint about honesty. A myth that organizes action makes demands, and it makes them independently of whether it is serving those it organizes. Luxemburg's treatment is preferred as an analysis: she took the mass strike to be a real process with observable dynamics rather than a mobilizing image, and argued from the actual record of the Russian strikes rather than from the effect of the idea on those holding it.⁵⁰ On proposition 128, the historical record is the argument, and the Spanish case is the one usually cited in both directions: the CNT's capacity in 1936 was the product of decades of workplace organization rather than of any culminating event, and the losses that followed are as instructive as the gains.⁵¹

XIV. Objections and Replies

Stated at their strongest, since a weak statement is a concession to nobody

i. That the error theory is self-defeating

The objection holds that denying all moral claims is itself a moral position, or that the denial cannot account for the evident force of moral experience. The first form is a confusion: the claim that there are no objective values is a claim about what exists, not a value judgement, and asserting that unicorns do not exist is not itself a unicorn. The second form is stronger and is answered by conceding it. Moral experience is forceful, universal, and explains a great deal of human behaviour. Error theory does not deny the experience; it denies its object, in the same way that explaining the phenomenology of a mirage does not require there to be water.

ii. That egoism cannot generate solidarity

This is the free-rider objection of section X and it is the serious one. The reply given there is not that egoists will feel solidarity anyway, but that the conditions under which cooperation is individually rational are identifiable, common in workplaces, and constructible where absent. The position accepts the consequence: where those conditions do not obtain, it predicts the union fails, and the historical record of union failure is consistent with that prediction to an uncomfortable degree.

iii. That Marx and Stirner cannot be combined

The objection cites “Saint Max” and is correct that Marx thought so. The reply is that the quarrel was about method and about the status of ideology rather than about the economics, and that nothing in the analysis of the commodity, of labour-power, or of surplus value depends on the philosophical anthropology Stirner attacked. What Marx and Stirner actually disagreed about is whether the critique of religion had gone far enough, and on that question this document sides with Stirner while taking Marx’s economics entire.

iv. That Camus rules out revolutionary politics altogether

Camus’s argument in *The Rebel* is directed at revolution that justifies present costs by a certified future, which is a description of the Jacobin and Bolshevik lineages rather than of syndicalism. His own sympathies ran toward the libertarian left and the Spanish exiles, and the position of section XIII — direct action, no guarantor, no vanguard, means not indemnified by ends — is closer to his than the standard reading of him as a quietist allows.⁵²

v. That this is right-libertarianism with different vocabulary

It is not, and the point of divergence is section VII. Right-libertarianism rests on a natural right to property, usually acquired through a theory of original appropriation and held as an entitlement prior to any social arrangement. That is a moral claim of precisely the kind section III denies, and removing it removes the whole structure. What remains is possession, occupancy and use, and the observation that title is enforced violence — which points in the opposite direction.

vi. That Stirner has been claimed by the far right

He has been, sporadically, and the claim does not survive reading him. Nationalism, race, the people, the leader, and destiny are fixed ideas of exactly the type his book exists to dissolve, and a movement demanding self-sacrifice to a collective essence is the purest instance of everything he attacked. The appropriation rests on reading the word “egoism” and stopping.⁵³

vii. That a position with no morality has no reason not to be monstrous

It has no moral reason. It has the reasons given throughout: that most people do not want to be monstrous and are not made to want it by a proof that they may be; that cruelty is expensive, destroys the reliability described in section XII, and invites reciprocation; and that a person who requires an external prohibition to keep them from atrocity is describing a fact about themselves rather than an argument against the position. It should also be noted that the historical record of atrocity is overwhelmingly a record of people acting under moral conviction rather than in its absence.

viii. That the pseudonym undermines the document’s authority

It would if the document had any. It is a statement of a position, and a position is assessed by whether its propositions hold rather than by the credentials of whoever set them down. The note on the name gives the positive reasons; the negative one is that an argument requiring a name attached to it in order to work is an argument relying on something other than itself.

The four sections that follow were not in the first draft of this document. They were added after the position had circulated and been pressed on points it had not adequately covered. They are held to the same rule given in proposition 138: recorded because the reasons for them hold, not because the document is obliged to appear complete.

XV. On Preference Formation and Adaptive Preference

What section III's account of wanting has not yet had to answer

139. Proposition 27 grounds action in preferences that are not objective but are nonetheless real and motivating. This account is adequate only if it can distinguish a preference from a preference produced, by the very arrangement it is then invoked to justify, in order to secure compliance with that arrangement.
140. Such preferences are not rare. A worker who has adjusted downward what they consider a fair wage, a reasonable workday, or a tolerable level of surveillance, in response to being denied better terms repeatedly, has not thereby discovered that the worse terms were what they wanted; the wanting has been fitted to the available options rather than the options assessed against a prior wanting.
141. This is not a claim that such a worker is deceived about some fact of the world; it is a claim about the causal history of a preference, and it is compatible with everything in section I, since proposition 8 already holds that the bundle is assembled from materials it did not choose.
142. The difficulty is that section III forecloses the obvious response. The reformer who says the adjusted preference is inauthentic, false, or a product of false consciousness is smuggling back exactly the kind of essential self that section I denies and the kind of objective standard that section III denies — a real preference against which the adapted one is measured and found wanting.
143. The response given here is not to certify some preferences as authentic and others as adaptive by appeal to an essence, but to examine causal history without moralizing it: a preference formed under conditions of restricted deliberation (proposition 15) is less stable under expansion of those conditions than a preference formed under conditions already fairly open, and this is an empirical difference rather than a metaphysical one.
144. It follows that an egoism attentive to this problem does not ask whether a preference is real — all preferences a bundle actually has are equally real — but asks what would happen to the preference if the conditions producing it changed. A preference that dissolves on contact with more time, more information, or a genuine alternative was doing work for someone other than the bundle holding it.
145. This test has a specific application to proposition 61. A person who retains an assigned category “having examined it and found it serviceable” is only doing what that proposition describes if the examination occurred under conditions in which discarding it was a live and low-cost option. Where it was not, retention is not evidence of ownness; it is evidence that the test was never actually run.
146. The same test bears on proposition 74's account of the wage contract as formally fair. A worker's acceptance of a wage is not thereby shown to be free of the distortion described here merely because no party threatened them in the moment of signing; the range of preferences available to be expressed was already narrowed by the same relation the acceptance is then cited to legitimate.
147. None of this licenses an outside party overriding the bundle's stated preference on the ground

that it has been diagnosed as adaptive. The diagnosis identifies a causal question, not a permission slip; a bundle whose preference survives expansion of its conditions has answered the question, and no further license is available to keep asking it once satisfied.

Elster's mechanism is adopted as the causal description: preferences adjust downward to match the feasible set, and the classic illustration — the fox who decides the grapes were sour once they proved unreachable — gives the phenomenon its name.⁵⁴ Elster and others have used the resulting problem to argue for welfare standards external to preference; Sen's related observation that the chronically deprived frequently report high contentment, and that this contentment is a poor guide to their actual position, is offered for the same reason and pushes toward a capability standard measured independently of what people say they want.⁵⁵ That further step is not taken here, for the reason given in proposition 142: an external standard against which stated preferences are checked and found inauthentic reinstates the essence section I spent its length denying. What is retained from Sen and Elster is narrower and, this document argues, sufficient: the diagnostic test of proposition 144, which asks a counterfactual question about a preference's stability rather than a metaphysical question about its authenticity, and which accordingly needs no standard external to the bundle to be run.

XVI. On Asymmetric Dependency

The reciprocity model's limit, stated rather than argued past

148. Sections IX, X, and XII ground obligation in a structure of mutual exposure: parties who can each affect the other's position, over an expected continuation of the relation, under conditions where defection is visible and costly. This structure is real and common, and where it holds the account given is adequate.
149. It does not hold, and does not approximately hold, between an infant and the adult who cares for it, between a person with a severe and lasting disability and an unpaid caregiver, between the dying and the attending, or between a prisoner and anyone outside the institution holding them. In each case one party cannot retaliate, cannot withdraw cooperation to material effect, and in some cases cannot be said to have interests the other party has any material need to court.
150. Proposition 125 addressed care for dependents by asserting that it is wanted and requires no further argument. This is true as far as it goes and does not meet the present objection, which is not about whether care is provided but about what account, internal to the position, explains why an egoist bundle's disposition to provide it should be regarded as anything more than a preference some bundles happen to have and others do not.
151. The honest position is that sections IX, X, and XII do not supply this account, and that no amount of extending the reciprocity model reaches it, because reciprocity is definitionally a relation between parties who can each move the other, and the case at hand is defined by the absence of exactly that.
152. Two moves are available and both are refused. The first reinstates an obligation grounded in the dependent's humanity, dignity, or personhood, which section III has already ruled out as a fixed idea wearing the vocabulary of description. The second denies that anything is owed at all, which is consistent with the position's formal commitments and is refused here anyway, on the ground given below.
153. What is offered instead is narrower and should be stated as such rather than dressed up as a solution. Dependency work is not owed by the position's own logic; it is undertaken, where it is undertaken well, by bundles whose own wanting includes the wellbeing of the dependent as a component of what they want, not as an instrument to it — the same relation proposition 120 describes for love, extended to a case where the object cannot reciprocate the regard.
154. Where that component is absent in a given bundle, the position has no further resource to supply it, and this should be recorded as a limit of the position rather than argued away. An account of ethics built entirely from leverage will underdetermine exactly the cases where leverage is structurally unavailable, and dependency is the paradigm case.
155. This limit has one further consequence worth drawing out. A society that arranges dependency work so that it is performed almost entirely by parties who are themselves poorly positioned to refuse it — a description that has applied, historically and at present, with great consistency to women, to racialized workers, and to the global poor — has not thereby solved the problem the reciprocity model cannot reach; it has located the cost where refusal is least available,

which is a fact about power of exactly the kind section VIII already has the vocabulary to name, redeployed here on terrain the wage relation does not cover.

Kittay's critique of contractarian theories of justice is aimed at exactly this gap: bargaining and reciprocity models of the social contract, whatever their other merits, represent relations between parties of roughly comparable power and cannot without distortion represent a relation to someone who cannot alter the terms of their own dependency. Her concept of nested dependency — that the person doing the caring is herself rendered vulnerable and dependent by the work of caring, and is in turn owed something the bargaining model cannot generate — is the sharpest statement of proposition 155's point.⁵⁶ MacIntyre reaches a structurally similar conclusion from an entirely different direction, arguing that any ethical account built from the standpoint of independent rational agency mischaracterizes a condition — dependence — that every such agent has passed through, will likely pass through again, and owes its capacity for agency to in the first place.⁵⁷ That two frameworks this document otherwise rejects (Kittay's is broadly contractarian, MacIntyre's is Aristotelian) converge on the same limit is a reason to record the limit rather than to treat it as an artifact of either framework's other commitments.

XVII. On the Normativity of Practical Reason

Whether proposition 26 owes a defense of its own

156. Proposition 26 holds that reasons for action survive the elimination of moral law, grounded in what the bundle wants and the situation it occupies. This proposition has so far been treated as needing no defense of its own, on the assumption that instrumental reason is metaphysically cheaper than moral law. The assumption should be examined rather than assumed.
157. The inference from “the bundle wants X” to “the bundle has a reason to pursue X,” and further to “the bundle ought, instrumentally, to take the means to X,” is not a report of a further fact discovered by introspection. It is a normative claim: that wanting generates reason. Section III’s argument against moral facts was that objective values would be entities of a metaphysically queer sort, detected by an equally queer faculty. The same question can be put to the norm of instrumental rationality: what kind of fact is “wanting X is a reason to pursue X,” and what detects it?
158. Two replies are available. The constructivist reply holds that the authority of instrumental reason is not discovered but constructed by the standpoint of any agent with ends at all — to have a want and to deliberate is already to have committed oneself to the norms that make deliberation about anything, including which action would satisfy the want. On this view the norm is not queer because it is not a further fact about the universe; it is a condition of the activity of willing itself, binding on anyone who wills anything, including the egoist.
159. The deflationary reply denies that instrumental rationality is a genuine requirement of reason at all, holding instead that “ought” claims of the form “you ought to take the means to your end” are elliptical for wide-scope requirements not to combine wanting an end, believing a certain means necessary, and failing to take it — a requirement that can always be satisfied by dropping the want instead of taking the means, and that consequently generates no reason to do anything in particular.
160. The deflationary reply is the more consistent extension of the error theory adopted in section III. It denies that there is any further fact, of any kind, compelling a bundle to act on its wants, and treats the appearance of such a fact as the same kind of illusion diagnosed throughout this document — the wheel in the head, this time turning under the hood of practical reason rather than morality.
161. Adopting the deflationary reply costs something and the cost should be named. It removes the ground on which proposition 26 rests reasons in wanting, and replaces it with the weaker claim that a bundle which wants X and believes M necessary to X will, as a matter of psychological fact rather than rational requirement, generally be disposed to pursue M — a description of how bundles tend to behave rather than a standard they can be shown to violate.
162. This is not a defect introduced by choosing badly between the two replies; it is what was already implied by section I. A bundle with no substantial self and no essence was never going to be found, on further inspection, to contain a categorical demand that it pursue its own ends. The demand, if there is one, was always going to turn out to be either constructed by the standpoint of agency itself, in which case it binds without needing to be discovered,

or absent, in which case what remains is disposition rather than requirement.

163. The position taken here is the deflationary one, for consistency with section III rather than because the constructivist reply has been refuted. It follows that proposition 26 should be read, from this point forward, as a description of what moves this bundle and bundles generally, not as the assertion of a standard the bundle would be irrational, in any sense carrying normative weight, to violate. Readers who prefer the constructivist reply lose nothing else in the document by adopting it instead; the two replies diverge only on how much philosophical weight proposition 26 was ever asked to bear.

Korsgaard's constructivism gives the strongest form of the first reply: the authority of practical reason is established by reflective endorsement from the standpoint of the agent, so that anyone who deliberates at all has already, in the act of deliberating, committed to the norms deliberation requires.⁵⁸ Broome's wide-scope analysis gives the technical form of the second: instrumental requirements bind combinations of attitudes rather than generating a free-standing reason for the means, which is exactly the gap proposition 159 exploits.⁵⁹ Kolodny presses the deflationary line furthest, arguing at length that there may be no genuine requirement of formal, means-end rationality at all — only substantive reasons for the particular attitudes rationality is thought to require.⁶⁰ The position adopted in proposition 163 follows Kolodny's conclusion without adopting his route to it; the reason given here is internal to section III's commitments rather than to Kolodny's independent argument, and a reader who rejects section III has no reason to prefer the deflationary reply over the constructivist one on the strength of anything said here.

XVIII. On Scale and Internationalism

The seam at the border, and the syndicate built on the wrong side of it

164. Section IX establishes that a workforce divided along any line is a workforce with a seam, and that closing the seam is self-defense rather than charity. Section VIII establishes that capital is mobile and that competition compels behavior no individual capitalist need have chosen. Neither section states the consequence of holding both at once: that the seam most consistently exploited by capital runs along national borders, and the syndicate as described through section IX is, by default, organized on the wrong side of it.
165. A union bounded by a national labor market bargains against an employer that is not so bounded. The employer's credible threat to relocate production, source components, or import labor under worse terms is not a threat made possible by any failure of solidarity within the union; it is a structural feature of the mismatch between the scale at which capital operates and the scale at which the union in question exists.
166. Proposition 94 anticipated that dependency runs further than it appears from the shop floor and named this a matter of causal chains rather than conscience. Applied at the scale of the nation-state, the same proposition entails that a syndicalism confined to a single country is organizing at a scale already known, by the document's own analysis, to be smaller than the dependency it is responding to.
167. The obstacle is not theoretical. Sections IX through XI treat organization, solidarity, and the state at a level of generality that does not distinguish the case where the relevant workers share a state, a language, and a legal order from the case where they do not, and the mechanisms proposed there — hiring halls, closed shops, informal shop-floor sanction, legal recognition and its costs — are mechanisms built for, and largely available only within, a single jurisdiction.
168. Internationalism cannot be secured by declaration. The formula of proposition 82 asserted at the scale of a single industry translates poorly into a slogan asserted at the scale of the globe, where the workers being asked to act in solidarity frequently do not share an employer, a legal order, or in the relevant sense a common position, and where the free-rider problem of section X reappears with the excludability mechanisms of proposition 102 largely unavailable across borders.
169. What can be salvaged from sections IX and X without pretending the scale problem is solved: the historical record shows coordinated action across borders succeeding precisely where the four conditions of section X are reconstructed at the appropriate scale — where benefits are made excludable through international framework agreements and coordinated certification, where the interaction is iterated through standing federations rather than one-off appeals, and where the same product or supply chain creates a durable and identifiable common exposure rather than an abstract common class position.
170. Where these conditions are not reconstructed, the honest prediction, following the method of section X and objection ii of section XIV, is that international solidarity will fail for the same structural reasons a workplace union fails when its own four conditions are absent, and appeals to international working-class unity in the absence of the conditions are a fixed idea

by the test of proposition 23: a demand made independently of the structure that would make acting on it rational.

171. Nothing in this section licenses indifference to workers elsewhere on the ground that no leverage connects a given bundle to them. Proposition 92 already fixes the boundary of obligation by the actual structure of dependency rather than by conscience, and the finding here is that the actual structure, examined honestly, is wider and more continuous across borders than a shop-floor view suggests — which argues for the harder work of constructing the conditions of section X at the appropriate scale, not for abandoning the requirement that those conditions be real before the obligation is asserted.

Silver’s study of labor unrest since 1870 documents capital’s recurring “spatial fix” — relocation in search of more governable labor — and the equally recurring finding that unrest reappears wherever capital’s mobility runs out, which is the empirical content behind proposition 169’s restatement of section X’s four conditions at international scale.⁶¹ Moody’s account of cross-border coordination under globally integrated supply chains is used here for the same reason Rucker was used in section IX: not as theory but as a record of what the tactic has actually required in practice, and of how often the four conditions have in fact been absent.⁶² Luxemburg’s earlier argument that capital accumulation requires continual expansion into a non-capitalist environment is cited again here, distinctly from her treatment of the mass strike in section XIII, because it is an early recognition — from within the tradition section VIII already draws on — that any analysis of capital confined to a single national economy was always going to be incomplete.⁶³

Closing

No substantial self, no uncaused will, no moral law, no meaning supplied from outside, no survival of death, no essence beneath the categories, no rightful title, no legitimate authority, no History guaranteeing an outcome, and no Cause requiring payment.

What remains is a bundle: its body, its wanting, its finite hours, its attributes held as property rather than as fate, its exposure to the same machinery as everyone standing beside it, and its associations — entered because they serve, maintained while they serve, and left when they stop.

This is not offered for belief. It is offered as a description of what serves the one writing it, set down under a name taken rather than given. If it serves you, the line is here to be held. If it does not, the loss is your own and remains your own affair.

catboystirnerite

Appendix A: What This Position Is Not

Not nihilism. The denial of objective value is not the denial that anything matters. Things matter to the people to whom they matter, which is the only way anything has ever mattered. What is refused is the further claim that they matter independently of anyone.

Not Randian egoism. Objectivism holds that rational self-interest is a moral obligation and derives it from a theory of human nature — two claims this document denies. An egoism that tells you what you ought to want has reinstated the structure it claimed to remove.

Not right-libertarianism. See objection v. The natural right to property is the load-bearing premise there and it is denied here.

Not Nietzscheanism. The resemblance is superficial and the differences are structural. There is no will to power here as a metaphysical principle, no hierarchy of types, no transvaluation producing a new table of values, and no *Übermensch*. Stirner and Nietzsche are routinely conflated and the question of influence is unresolved.

Not solipsism. Other people exist, their interests are as real as one's own, and nothing in the position suggests otherwise. What is denied is that their interests generate claims on one independent of any relation in which one stands to them.

Not anti-organizational. The union is central. What is refused is the union that makes demands in its own name, which is a different object.

Not vanguardism. See sections IV and XI.

Not a rejection of feeling. Affection, loyalty, disgust, and grief are facts about the bundle and are neither suspect nor in need of justification. What is refused is their conversion into obligations that persist after the feeling has gone.

Not fascism, and not available to it. See objection vi. Every constitutive element of that politics — nation, race, destiny, leader, sacrifice to a collective essence — is a fixed idea by the test in proposition 26.

Not a claim of false consciousness. Section XV's account of adaptive preference does not certify some preferences as authentic and others as manufactured by appeal to an essence the bundle lacks; it asks a causal question about what a preference does under expanded conditions, and treats the answer as evidence rather than as a license for an outside party to override what the bundle currently wants.

Not a complete ethics. Section XVI records, rather than closes, a gap: the position has no account of why a bundle should extend regard to a party who cannot reciprocate it, beyond noting that some bundles want to and some do not. Appendix A lists this as a limit deliberately, since the alternative — a quiet elision — is the kind of smoothing the preamble already disclaims.

Not cosmopolitanism owed to humanity in general. The internationalism argued for in section XVIII is not owed to humanity as such, which section III has already ruled out as a ground for

anything; it is owed exactly as far as the structure of dependency in proposition 92 actually runs, traced now across borders rather than stopped at them, and no further.

Appendix B: Glossary of Terms

Absurd. The relation obtaining between a mind demanding sense and a world returning none. A relation, not a property of either term.

Adaptive preference. A want whose content has been shaped by the restriction of the options available to the bundle holding it. Section XV proposes to examine such a preference by its stability under an expansion of those options, rather than by appeal to a supposedly authentic preference beneath it.

Amoralism. The practice corresponding to error theory: acting on one's own reasons without reference to moral facts, which do not exist.

Asymmetric dependency. A relation in which one party cannot reciprocate, retaliate, or withdraw cooperation to material effect. Section XVI identifies it as a case the reciprocity-based account of sections IX, X, and XII does not reach.

Bundle. A person, described accurately. A collection of perceptions, dispositions, memories and impulses unified by continuity rather than by an underlying substance.

Creative nothing. Stirner's term for the unique one considered as the source of its own creations rather than as a fixed essence expressing itself.

Error theory. The position that moral claims assert objective facts, that there are no such facts, and that moral claims are therefore uniformly false.

Fixed idea. An abstraction which has been elevated above the person holding it and which makes demands independently of its usefulness to them. Synonymous with spook.

Ownness (*Eigenheit*). The relation of a thing being one's own, requiring no permission. Contrasted with freedom, which is granted and therefore revocable.

Philosophical suicide. Camus's term for the evasion of the absurd by a leap into a transcendent guarantor, whether religious or secular.

Possession. What one holds and uses, as distinct from property, which is what an authority certifies one may call on it to defend.

Seam. A division within a workforce along which an employer can apply pressure. See propositions 56 and 86; section XVIII treats the border as a seam of this kind.

Spook (*Spuk*). See fixed idea. The wheel in the head.

Union of egoists (*Verein von Egoisten*). An association entered into and maintained for the sake of its members' own interests, dissoluble at will, and distinguished from a society which stands over its members.

Unique one (der Einzige). Stirner's term for the individual considered as unclassifiable — not an instance of a kind, and therefore not addressable by claims directed at the kind.

Appendix C: Note on Lineage

This position does not descend from a school, and the following is a record of borrowings rather than a claim of succession.

The egoist line begins with the publication of *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum* in Leipzig in the autumn of 1844, at the tail end of the Young Hegelian moment and shortly before it was closed down by censorship and by the events of 1848. Its author, a schoolmaster who published under an assumed name and died in obscurity in 1856, wrote nothing else of comparable weight and was substantially forgotten until John Henry Mackay's biographical recovery at the end of the century.

The American reception ran through Benjamin Tucker and the circle around Liberty, which converted from natural-rights individualism to egoism in the 1880s and published the first English translation in 1907; James L. Walker's *The Philosophy of Egoism* is the most systematic native statement from that milieu. The British reception ran through Dora Marsden and *The Egoist*, better remembered now for serializing modernist fiction than for the egoism that gave it its name. The Italian individualist current produced Renzo Novatore, whose formulations are more lyrical than analytic and whose insistence that the individual is a creative nothing rather than a program is retained here in substance.

The syndicalist line is separate and largely unaware of the first. It runs from the Bourses du Travail and the French CGT of the 1890s through the Charter of Amiens, the IWW after 1905, the Italian USI, the Argentine FORA, and the Spanish CNT, which remains the largest anarcho-syndicalist organization ever built and the only one to have administered anything at scale. Rocker's 1938 exposition is the standard theoretical statement and was written as the Spanish case was being lost.

The two lines meet rarely and generally in mutual suspicion. Where they have met — in parts of the Italian individualist milieu, in the post-left anarchist writing of the late twentieth century, and in the small literature on egoist communism — the result has usually been a rejection of organization rather than a reconstruction of it. This document attempts the reconstruction instead, and the analytical tools it uses for the purpose — Olson, Axelrod, Ostrom — come from outside both traditions and postdate them by a century.

Absurdism enters from a third direction entirely and has no anarchist pedigree, though Camus's own sympathies were closer to this tradition than his reputation suggests. Its function here is specific and limited: it supplies the account of meaning that egoism needs and does not contain, and it supplies the argument against guarantors that keeps a syndicalism from becoming a church.

Sections XV through XVIII draw on a fourth set of tools entirely, assembled after the fact to answer objections the first three lines did not anticipate: welfare economics and the theory of adaptive preference (Elster, Sen) for section XV; feminist and virtue-ethical critiques of contractarianism (Kittay,

MacIntyre) for section XVI; the metaethics of practical reason (Korsgaard, Broome, Kolodny) for section XVII; and labor history and world-systems-adjacent political economy (Silver, Moody, and Luxemburg's earlier work read a second time) for section XVIII. None of these four literatures is in dialogue with the other three, which is itself a fact worth noting: a position assembled from as many directions as this one accumulates its gaps from as many directions as it accumulates its resources, and there is no reason to expect the accumulation of gaps to have stopped here.

Notes

1. The practice is near-universal in the tradition. “Max Stirner” was itself a pseudonym: the author of *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum* was Johann Kaspar Schmidt (1806–1856), the name deriving from a nickname referring to his high forehead (Stirn). See John Henry Mackay, *Max Stirner: Sein Leben und sein Werk* (Berlin: Schuster & Loeffler, 1898), the source of nearly everything known about his biography.
2. The tension is standard in the literature on individualist and post-left anarchism: Stirner’s critique of fixed ideas applies straightforwardly to class, solidarity and the union, and many of his readers have drawn exactly that conclusion. The reply offered in section IX is that a dependency is not a fixed idea but an observable relation, and that the test for whether one is dealing with a spook is whether the thing makes demands independent of its usefulness.
3. Marx and Engels, *The German Ideology* (written 1845–46; first published in full 1932), Volume I, Part III, “Saint Max” — a polemic against Stirner’s *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum* occupying the greater part of the manuscript. The disproportion is itself evidence of how seriously Stirner was taken by the people dismissing him.
4. The rupture followed the publication of *L’Homme révolté* (1951) and the hostile review by Francis Jeanson in *Les Temps modernes* (1952), followed by an exchange between Camus and Sartre in the same journal. They did not reconcile.
5. David Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature* (1739–40), Book I, Part IV, Section VI, “Of Personal Identity.” Hume himself came to regard the account as unsatisfactory; the Appendix to the *Treatise* retracts his confidence in it while offering no replacement, which is a candour worth imitating.
6. The chariot analogy appears in the *Milindapañha* (The Questions of King Milinda, c. 1st century BCE–2nd century CE), in the dialogue between the monk Nāgasena and King Menander, and earlier in the *Vajirā Sutta* (*Saṃyutta Nikāya* 5.10). The convergence with Hume is noted often enough that a direct line of transmission has been proposed and disputed; nothing here depends on the historical question.
7. Derek Parfit, *Reasons and Persons* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1984), Part III, especially chapters 10–13. Parfit reported finding the conclusion liberating rather than distressing — that the walls of the glass tunnel of the self had disappeared — which is the same reaction recorded in proposition 5.
8. Max Stirner, *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum* (Leipzig: Otto Wigand, 1844; title page dated 1845). English: *The Ego and Its Own*, ed. David Leopold, trans. Steven Byington (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995). The creative nothing frames the book, appearing in the introduction and returning at the close.
9. Hume, *Treatise*, Book II, Part III, Sections I–II; and *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding* (1748), Section VIII, “Of Liberty and Necessity,” where he calls the dispute the most contentious question in metaphysics and proposes to settle it by fixing the meaning of the words.
10. Harry G. Frankfurt, “Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person,” *The Journal of Philosophy* 68, no. 1 (1971): 5–20. The fit with egoism is close: the question is never whether

the wanting was caused, but whose wanting it is.

11. P. F. Strawson, “Freedom and Resentment,” *Proceedings of the British Academy* 48 (1962): 187–211. Adopted here only in part: the reactive attitudes are granted as facts about how people function, but are not treated as grounding desert, which section III has already denied.
12. Daniel C. Dennett, *Elbow Room: The Varieties of Free Will Worth Wanting* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1984); and *Freedom Evolves* (New York: Viking, 2003).
13. Galen Strawson, “The Impossibility of Moral Responsibility,” *Philosophical Studies* 75 (1994): 5–24. The argument is accepted here as sound against moral responsibility, which is precisely why section III denies there is any. It does not touch ownership, which requires only that the action issued from this bundle rather than another.
14. Benjamin Libet et al., “Time of Conscious Intention to Act in Relation to Onset of Cerebral Activity,” *Brain* 106 (1983): 623–642; for the accumulator critique, Aaron Schurger, Jacobo D. Sitt and Stanislas Dehaene, “An Accumulator Model for Spontaneous Neural Activity Prior to Self-Initiated Movement,” *PNAS* 109, no. 42 (2012): E2904–E2913. Alfred Mele, *Free: Why Science Hasn’t Disproved Free Will* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2014), surveys the overreach.
15. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, “My Power.”
16. J. L. Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1977), chapter 1, “The Subjectivity of Values”; the arguments from relativity and queerness are at sections 8 and 9. Mackie’s first sentence — the flat denial of objective values — is deliberately placed before any argument, which he defends as a statement of what is to be shown.
17. Mackie, *Ethics*, chapters 5–9, and the subtitle *Inventing Right and Wrong*. The divergence is marked here rather than hidden: this document accepts Mackie’s first chapter and declines his constructive programme, on the ground given in proposition 26 — that a knowingly invented morality is precisely how a useful fiction becomes a fixed idea, since the invention is forgotten within a generation and the fiction is not.
18. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part I (“Man”), on the sacred, the fixed idea, and the wheels in the head.
19. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part I, section on “The Free” — the critique of Feuerbach, of political liberalism, of social liberalism, and of humane liberalism as three successive relocations of the same authority.
20. Albert Camus, *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (Paris: Gallimard, 1942); English: *The Myth of Sisyphus*, trans. Justin O’Brien (New York: Knopf, 1955), opening chapter, “An Absurd Reasoning: Absurdity and Suicide.”
21. Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*, “Absurd Walls.” The point is easy to miss and frequently is: the world is not absurd, and neither is the person. The relation is.
22. Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*, “Philosophical Suicide,” directed principally at Kierkegaard, Chestov, Jaspers and Husserl; the injunction to live without appeal follows in “Absurd Freedom.”
23. Albert Camus, *L’Homme révolté* (Paris: Gallimard, 1951); English: *The Rebel*, trans. Anthony Bower (New York: Knopf, 1956), especially the sections on historical rebellion, on the

- regicides, and on state terrorism. This is the book that ended the friendship with Sartre and Camus's standing on the French left.
24. Thomas Nagel, "The Absurd," *The Journal of Philosophy* 68, no. 20 (1971): 716–727. Nagel explicitly declines Camus's dramatic register, suggesting the situation calls for irony rather than defiance.
 25. Epicurus, "Letter to Menoeceus," preserved in Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of the Eminent Philosophers*, Book X; and the *Principal Doctrines*, II. Lucretius extends the argument with the symmetry between the time before birth and the time after death in *De Rerum Natura*, Book III.
 26. Thomas Nagel, "Death," *Noûs* 4, no. 1 (1970): 73–80; reprinted in *Mortal Questions* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1979). Propositions 40–41 accept Nagel's correction.
 27. Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*, "Absurd Walls" and "The Absurd Man." The consolatory argument is on his account another form of the leap.
 28. Karl Marx, *Capital* I, chapter 10, "The Working Day," including the extended documentary sections drawn from the reports of the factory inspectors.
 29. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, "Ownness" (*Eigenheit*). His formulation is that one is free from what one is rid of, and owner of what one has in one's power — the same reduction of right to capacity noted in section II.
 30. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, "My Power" and "My Self-Enjoyment."
 31. Kwame Anthony Appiah, "The Uncompleted Argument: Du Bois and the Illusion of Race," *Critical Inquiry* 12, no. 1 (1985): 21–37; and *In My Father's House: Africa in the Philosophy of Culture* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992), chapter 1. Appiah's later work is considerably more sympathetic to identity as a practical resource than proposition 56 is, and the divergence is one of emphasis rather than of metaphysics.
 32. Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (New York: Routledge, 1990), chapter 1 and conclusion; Simone de Beauvoir, *Le Deuxième Sexe* (Paris: Gallimard, 1949), Volume II, Part I, opening sentence.
 33. Judith Butler, *Bodies That Matter: On the Discursive Limits of "Sex"* (New York: Routledge, 1993), preface and chapter 1, where the voluntarist reading of *Gender Trouble* is addressed directly and rejected.
 34. Pierre-Joseph Proudhon, *Qu'est-ce que la propriété?* (Paris, 1840); English: *What Is Property?*, trans. Donald R. Kelley and Bonnie G. Smith (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994). Proudhon distinguishes property from possession in the same work and defends the latter, which is the distinction adopted in propositions 58–59.
 35. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, "My Power" and the section on property within "My Intercourse." His argument against Proudhon and against communism is in the same part: both, he claims, address themselves to a society which then holds the property in place of the individual, substituting one proprietor for another.
 36. Benjamin R. Tucker, *Instead of a Book, by a Man Too Busy to Write One* (New York, 1893), and the *file of Liberty* (1881–1908). Tucker converted publicly to egoism after reading Stirner and published Byington's translation in 1907; the earlier natural-rights position he abandoned

is a useful record of the argument being lost.

37. Peter Kropotkin, *La Conquête du pain* (Paris, 1892); English: *The Conquest of Bread* (London: Chapman & Hall, 1906), chapters 1 and 13, on the impossibility of isolating individual contribution within an inherited collective productive apparatus.
38. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, “My Intercourse” — the distinction between the union (*Verein*) and society (*Gesellschaft*). The examples he gives are deliberately small and domestic, which is one reason the political application has had to be supplied by others.
39. Max Stirner, *The Unique and Its Property*, trans. Wolfi Landstreicher (Baltimore: Underworld Amusements, 2017). The choice between translations is contested; readers checking the argument should be aware that “ego,” “property,” and “union” all render German terms whose English equivalents carry unwanted freight.
40. Rudolf Rocker, *Anarcho-Syndicalism* (London: Secker & Warburg, 1938), especially the chapters on the objectives and the methods of anarcho-syndicalism.
41. Preamble to the Constitution of the Industrial Workers of the World, adopted 1905 and amended subsequently; the phrase itself long predates the organization.
42. Charte d’Amiens, adopted by the Confédération Générale du Travail at its Amiens congress, October 1906. See also Fernand Pelloutier’s earlier work with the Bourses du Travail, *Histoire des Bourses du Travail* (Paris, 1902).
43. Robert Axelrod, *The Evolution of Cooperation* (New York: Basic Books, 1984). The result is precisely what an egoist syndicalism requires: cooperation as the dominant strategy for self-interested parties under repeated interaction, with no moral premise supplied.
44. Elinor Ostrom, *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990). Her design principles — clearly defined boundaries, graduated sanctions, collective-choice arrangements, nested enterprises — read as a specification for the kind of union described in propositions 76 and 90.
45. Max Weber, “Politik als Beruf” (1919); English: “Politics as a Vocation,” in *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, ed. and trans. H. H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills (New York: Oxford University Press, 1946). Weber’s insistence on defining the state by means rather than ends is exactly what makes the definition usable for an anarchist purpose.
46. Mikhail Bakunin, *Gosudarstvennost’ i anarkhiia* (1873); English: *Statism and Anarchy*, ed. and trans. Marshall Shatz (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), especially the appendix on the Marxist conception of the transitional state.
47. Rocker, *Anarcho-Syndicalism*, on direct action and the rejection of parliamentary methods: power exercised through delegates becomes the delegates’ power.
48. Peter Kropotkin, *Mutual Aid: A Factor of Evolution* (London: Heinemann, 1902), written against the social-Darwinist reading of competition. The evolutionary argument has been substantially vindicated in its general shape by later work on reciprocal altruism and kin selection, though not in all its particulars.
49. Georges Sorel, *Réflexions sur la violence* (Paris, 1908); English: *Reflections on Violence*, ed. Jeremy Jennings (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), chapter 4. Sorel’s later political trajectory, and the uses made of the concept of the mobilizing myth by movements he

did not anticipate, are a practical argument against the device independent of the theoretical one given here.

50. Rosa Luxemburg, *Massenstreik, Partei und Gewerkschaften* (Hamburg, 1906); English: *The Mass Strike, the Political Party and the Trade Unions*. Adopted here for the analysis of strike dynamics and not for her position on the party, which sections XI and XIII reject.
51. See José Peirats, *La CNT en la revolución española*, 3 vols. (Toulouse, 1951–1953); English: *The CNT in the Spanish Revolution* (Hastings: ChristieBooks, 2001–2006). Nothing here is intended as a verdict on the collectivizations, on which the literature is enormous and partisan in every direction.
52. Camus’s associations with the anarchist and syndicalist press, including *Le Libertaire* and *Solidaridad Obrera*, and his support for the Spanish exile community, are documented in Olivier Todd, *Albert Camus: une vie* (Paris: Gallimard, 1996); English: *Albert Camus: A Life*, trans. Benjamin Ivry (New York: Knopf, 1997).
53. On the general problem of Stirner’s reception and its varied appropriations, see David Leopold’s introduction to the Cambridge edition, and R. W. K. Paterson, *The Nihilistic Egoist: Max Stirner* (London: Oxford University Press, 1971), which is hostile to Stirner but careful about what he actually argued.
54. Jon Elster, *Sour Grapes: Studies in the Subversion of Rationality* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983), chapter 3, “Sour Grapes.” Elster’s mechanism — preferences adjusting downward to match the feasible set — is adopted here as a causal description and not, as in some of its uses, as grounds for an outside party to override the resulting preference.
55. Amartya Sen, *Inequality Reexamined* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1992), chapter 3, on the “contentment of the deprived” as a poor guide to their actual position; and *Development as Freedom* (New York: Knopf, 1999). Sen’s use of the problem to argue for a capability standard external to preference is not adopted here, for the reason given in proposition 142.
56. Eva Feder Kittay, *Love’s Labor: Essays on Women, Equality, and Dependency* (New York: Routledge, 1999), especially the critique of contractarian theories of justice for their inability to represent relations between unequals who cannot alter their own condition of dependency, and the concept of “nested dependency,” by which the position of the dependency worker is itself precarious and itself unaddressed by a bargaining model.
57. Alasdair MacIntyre, *Dependent Rational Animals: Why Human Beings Need the Virtues* (Chicago: Open Court, 1999), reaching a structurally similar conclusion from a virtue-ethical starting point sections III and IX both reject; the convergence of two very different frameworks on the same gap is one of the reasons it is recorded here as a limit rather than argued past.
58. Christine M. Korsgaard, *The Sources of Normativity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), the Tanner Lectures and commentary together, for the constructivist claim that the authority of practical reason is established by reflective endorsement from the standpoint of the agent rather than discovered as an external fact.
59. John Broome, *Rationality Through Reasoning* (Chichester: Wiley-Blackwell, 2013), on the wide-scope analysis of instrumental requirements and the resulting difficulty in deriving any

specific reason from the mere possession of an end.

60. Niko Kolodny, “Why Be Rational?”, *Mind* 114, no. 455 (2005): 509–563, arguing at length that there may be no genuine requirement of formal (means-end) rationality at all, only substantive reasons for the particular attitudes rationality is thought to require — a conclusion the deflationary reply above adopts for reasons internal to section III rather than for Kolodny’s own.
61. Beverly J. Silver, *Forces of Labor: Workers’ Movements and Globalization since 1870* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003), on capital’s “spatial fix” — relocation in search of more governable labor — and on the recurring finding that labor unrest reappears wherever capital cannot easily relocate, which is the empirical content behind proposition 169’s four conditions restated at the international scale.
62. Kim Moody, *Workers in a Lean World: Unions in the International Economy* (London: Verso, 1997), on the practical construction of cross-border labor coordination under lean production and globally integrated supply chains, and the conditions under which it has and has not held.
63. Rosa Luxemburg, *Die Akkumulation des Kapitals* (1913); English: *The Accumulation of Capital*, trans. Agnes Schwarzschild (London: Routledge, 1951), arguing that capital accumulation requires continual expansion into a non-capitalist environment — an early recognition, from within the tradition section VIII already draws on, that any analysis of capital confined to a single national economy is necessarily incomplete.

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